

Basic Geometric Shapes

Squares, circles, triangles & the forms they build

Every object in the world can be broken down into basic geometric shapes. Mastering these flat 2D primitives — and their 3D counterparts — gives you a universal vocabulary for drawing anything.

KEY CONCEPTS

The Six Primitives

2D: circle, square, triangle. 3D: sphere, cube, cone (and cylinder). These six forms are the building blocks of everything. A car is a box. A head is a sphere. A finger is a cylinder. Learning to see this way transforms how you draw from observation.

Shape Analysis

When drawing from reference, squint to blur detail — this reveals the underlying shape structure. Ask: what big shape is this? What smaller shapes break it down? Draw the largest shape first, then subdivide.

Drawing Accurate Squares

Draw two parallel vertical lines first. Then add the horizontal top and bottom, checking that they're parallel and equal in width. Use light construction lines and check diagonals — they should be equal length and bisect at the center.

Combining Shapes

Complex objects are combinations of simple shapes. A lamp: cylinder + sphere. A chair: boxes. A hand: a flat box (palm) with cylinders (fingers). Practice this analytical thinking with everything you see.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw 5 household objects using only flat geometric shapes (no detail).
2. Create a 'shape library': draw each primitive 20× in different orientations.
3. Pick one complex object and do a shape-breakdown diagram of it.

FURTHER READING

■ Ctrl+Paint – Basic Shapes

<https://www.ctrlpaint.com/videos/basic-shapes>

■ Draw a Box – Boxes